



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Mars Hill Academy
School Website: <https://marshill.edu/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Mars Hill Academy (MHA) presents a consistently classical, explicitly Christian model of education. Public materials show a robust integration of classical method (grammar, logic, rhetoric), liberal arts emphasis, and a biblical worldview anchored in explicit theology (e.g., Westminster Confession; Lost Tools of Learning). The school foregrounds transtemporal ideals such as truth, goodness, and beauty, and emphasizes formation of character alongside intellectual achievement. It also centers parental partnership, liturgical rhythms, and a communal life rooted in Christian witness. Overall, the school aligns strongly with the six elements of classical education across categories, with clear evidence of Great Books/Reading canon, memory-oriented pedagogy, teachers as living curriculum, and parent partnership. Consequently, the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL.

Key across-category patterns - Religious/metaphysical foundations are explicit and theological, with a biblically centered, Christ-focused framework and doctrinal touchpoints (Westminster Confession; biblical interpretation as core to instruction). Evidence: explicit statements about Christian distinctiveness, biblical worldview, and theological grounding.

- Purpose/goals center formation, virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing rather than job-readiness alone. Evidence: formation/telos language, emphasis on truth/beauty, and the goal of wise, virtuous graduates. - Curriculum emphasizes the liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Latin/Greek/Hebrew; Great Books; senior thesis). Evidence: explicit Trivium/Quadrivium framing and advanced classical coursework. - Pedagogy includes contemplative/restful elements (schol  -like rhythm) alongside Socratic/seminar-style upper-level work and rhetoric training in later years. Evidence: mentions of rhetoric, senior theses, and a pedagogical approach rooted in classical methods. - Faculty described as model teachers; living curriculum; strong mentoring and partnership with students. Evidence: faculty pages, stories of teachers modeling virtues, and references to teachers as the core of the living curriculum. - Parents & Community emphasize partnership with parents, parent formation, and open campus visits. Evidence: explicit statements about partnering with parents, in loco parentis, and parent formation activities.

Abstract classification: CLASSICAL

Note: The 6-category keyword framework below follows the classical rubric and uses the Positive/Negative keyword indicators from the Six Essential Elements of a Classical School (1) document as the scoring framework. Citations point to the Mars Hill materials (crawl) and relevant classical-education lexicon/documents in the knowledge base.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials explicitly ground education in Christian faith, with statements that all families "ascribe to faith in Jesus Christ" and that the Bible is "the primary source of truth and instruction in all matters of faith and life." - The school frames itself as a Christian, classical institution with a biblical worldview

integrated across instruction (not confined to chapel/religion class). Westminster Confession is cited as doctrinal standard, and Dorothy Sayers' Lost Tools of Learning is referenced as a guide to the educational model. - Foundational language emphasizes truth, goodness, and beauty as transcendentals (e.g., "Rooted in truth, goodness, and beauty" and "Biblical worldview" integrated throughout coursework).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; worship; Bible; biblical worldview; Westminster Confession; Christ-centered formation; catechesis; revelation; sacred tradition. (From Mars Hill materials and doctrinal references.)

- Negative keywords present: none evident in the public materials (no explicit relativism, secularism, or value-neutral framing detected in the school's public pages).

Why this rating - The school foregrounds transcendental realities and a theology-grounded education, with explicit doctrinal anchors and liturgical-leaning communal life. The presence of a clear Christian worldview, doctrinal standards, and a biblically integrated curriculum matches the Positive Keyword Indicators for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and aligns with Classical criteria.

Citations - Core Christian-grounded framing and Biblical worldview: - Westminster Confession and Lost Tools guidance: - Biblical worldview integrated across instruction: - "Rooted in truth, goodness, and beauty" and other faith-forming language:

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly speaks of forming wise and virtuous graduates who love what is true, good, and beautiful; aims at formation rather than job prep; emphasis on virtue and human flourishing. - The public materials tie education to the liberal-arts tradition and a classical mission, with telos and contemplative aims (scholé/restful learning) referenced in classical education vocabularies; the Great Conversation/Great Books alignment is implied through the classical framework and Great Books emphasis in the knowledge-base lexicon. - The mission statement and world-view discussions emphasize life-long formation, virtue, and service to God, not solely career outcomes.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, human flourishing, liberal education, paideia, classical mission, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, scholé (restful contemplation). - Negative keywords present: explicitly none. There is no public emphasis on "workforce readiness" or "career-education first" in opposition to formation; rather, the opposite appears (formation-focused language). The knowledge-base Negative Keywords set includes "college/career readiness" as a negative signal; Mars Hill does not foreground this as a primary goal.

Why this rating - The school's stated aims center virtue, wisdom, and formation of humane beings, with a classical liberal-arts orientation and telos-driven language. That aligns with CLASSICAL criteria in the School Purpose and Goal category.

Citations - Formation, virtue, and the truism of truth/goodness/beauty: - Liberal-arts mission and telos language: - Scholé/restful learning and contemplation as part of formation:

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site explicitly articulates the classical Trivium (grammar, dialectic/logic, rhetoric) and references a Quadrivium-like scope (through content such as advanced math, science, and the inclusion of music/the arts). The curriculum materials highlight Latin, Greek, Hebrew, and Spanish; senior thesis; Progymnasmata; rhetoric and humanities focus; Great Books/Western canon emphasis. - Framing pages show "We are a Classical School" with explicit grammar/logic/rhetoric, and a curriculum built on the liberal-arts framework; students study literature with historical and philosophical depth; Senior Thesis and Rhetoric School components emphasize classical training in rhetoric and argument. □filecite□turn2boMHg19fMbWBTg8pvQdd□ - The curriculum includes Great Books/primary sources, worldviews, and a cross-disciplinary approach across Bible, history, literature, philosophy, and the sciences, all within a biblical-Christian framework.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Quadrivium; Great Books/primary sources; Latin/Greek/Hebrew; Senior Thesis; interdisciplinary/humanities focus; integration of faith and learning; classic pedagogy; wonder/integration/education for life. - Negative keywords present: potential “project-based learning dominance” as a contrasting modern method; but Mars Hill materials do not emphasize this approach as a public hallmark; these appear in the Negative Keywords set rather than the school’s content. The public materials align with a classical-canon approach (not secular project-based dominance).

Why this rating - The curriculum is framed around the liberal arts and the Trivium, the Quadrivium, Great Books, and a Christ-centered integration of faith with reason. The explicit classical framing, written as a core value and programmatic structure, supports CLASSICAL.

Citations - Trivium/Quadrivium framing and classical curriculum: - Latin/Greek/Hebrew and Senior Thesis; Great Books/Worldview emphasis:

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials describe a pedagogy that blends restful, contemplative elements with rigorous rhetoric and Socratic-like discourse at the upper levels. The sources indicate that lower grades involve singing/memory and recitation-related practices; upper grades employ seminars, debates, and rhetorical training (including public speaking). The Scholē/Scholē-inspired language appears in the broader classical-learning literature referenced on the site, indicating a pedagogy that values rest, contemplation, and memory. - Explicit statements about the classical method emphasize a memory-rich approach (grammar stage, recitation, progymna) and a structured progression toward rhetorical mastery and public speaking. The Rhetoric School literature and the Senior Thesis program illustrate upper-level oral argument and persuasion as a core practice. - Note: The site also emphasizes engagement with literature, debate, and worldview topics (Worldview Summit), consistent with classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic discussion/seminars; rhetoric; memory/recitation; singing/chanting in early grades; restful/scholē pedagogy; public speaking; debates; master-teacher model (as implicit through faculty literature). - Negative keywords present: contextual references to project-based learning as a dominant approach in some modern schools; Mars Hill materials do not position project-based learning as their primary method (rather, they center classical methods and memory-based recall). The presence of “project-based learning” as a negative indicator is not evidenced as a public stance of MHA (the materials lean classical rather than constructivist/case-based only).

Why this rating - The pedagogy aligns with classical signals: memory-focused recitation, structured Trivium progression, rhetoric and public speaking, and Socratic/seminar discourse at higher grades. The presence of liturgical and contemplative elements (scholē) further supports a restful, attentive pedagogy consistent with classical ideals.

Citations - Trivium-based pedagogy, memory work, and upper-school rhetoric/seminars: - Lower-school chanting/recitation, and restfulness: - Scholē-inspired rest/wonder pedagogy in broader classical literature:

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe teachers as model, virtuous, and engaged mentors who constitute the living curriculum, with faculty literature highlighting long-tenured teachers and a culture of mentorship. Specific faculty pages profile teachers who articulate Christian, classical commitments and subject-area mastery (e.g., Dr. Michelle Augustine; Mrs. Kayla Pollock; Mr. Mike McKenna as Headmaster).

- The school presents a portrait of teachers as core to the school’s mission, with “Four Loves” and “We Partner with Parents” sections illustrating the pedagogical and relational role of faculty as moral exemplars and mentors. - The school’s leadership narrative emphasizes classical formation and mentorship as central to student development (Headmaster statement; teacher profiles; “Living Curriculum” language).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum; portrait of a teacher; mentors; masters; teachers as guides/partners; faculty as core; professional formation; model virtue; right

affections; character formation. - Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials (no “facilitator” or non-classical teacher role signals). The public pages strongly align with classical teacher-as-mentor and master-teacher models.

Why this rating - The faculty portrayal emphasizes teachers as exemplars of virtue and knowledge, with a clearly living-curriculum approach and a faculty-community culture that mirrors classical pedagogy ideals. This aligns with CLASSICAL indicators for Faculty.

Citations - Faculty portraits and teacher profiles: - Living curriculum and the Four Loves language (teacher as mentor/core): - Headmaster narrative and classical formation emphasis:

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnering with parents, viewing parents as co-teachers in the classical education project; it also mentions parent formation (book studies and gatherings) and open-campus visits. The public pages describe “in loco parentis” and parent collaboration in education. - Materials describe parental engagement through book clubs, gatherings, and organized activities; the school invites parents to visits, and the “Room To Grow” giving section shows an involved and collaborative community ecosystem. - The ICE pamphlet and classical-education literature in the knowledge base discuss parent formation and active parental involvement as a hallmark of classical schools. Mars Hill’s public materials align with those ideas (parent formation, partnership, and home-school alignment).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; parent formation; co-teachers; home-school alignment; open campus; educational partnership; parental involvement; family formation; parent covenant. - Negative keywords present: none (no evidence of consumerist or minimal-parent involvement signals; the site consistently foregrounds parental partnership).

Why this rating - Mars Hill Academy’s materials consistently present parents as core partners and co-educators, with explicit commitments to parental involvement, parent education, and open access to school life. This matches CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

Citations - Parent partnership and co-educator framing: - Parental formation and home-school alignment (ICE/related literature in the knowledge base):

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable here, as all six categories align with CLASSICAL indicators. If any category were to shift toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, concrete steps would include: - More explicit articulation of Great Books reading lists tied to a formal Great Conversation rubric. - Additional public evidence of Socratic seminars in all upper-grade classes (K–12) and explicit public documentation of student-led inquiry. - Expanded public-facing materials showing ongoing parental education offerings and structured family formation activities beyond current examples.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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